Directorate's (ED) custody for interrogation after a Ranchi court allowed it five days of remand. A judicial order allowed him to participate in the floor test process.

In its remand note, the ED has claimed that one of the main accused in the land scam—revenue sub-inspector Bhanu Pratap Prasad—hatched a conspiracy to illegally acquire unlisted properties forcefully or through falsification of government records and/ or tampering with revenue documents. The ED case against Hemant is related to the illegal acquisition of 12 plots of land, totalling 8.5 acres, in Ranchi's Bargain circle that Prasad allegedly arranged for him. The ED claims Hemant was directly linked with the acquisition, possession and use of proceeds from the so-called scam. Hemant has contested this claim, daring the agency to show any transfer paper in his name. "If the accusations are proved, if they place on record one paper about owning any land illegally, I will leave Jharkhand, not just politics," he said.

"Soren is knowingly a party with Bhanu Pratap Prasad in activities connected with concealment of the original records for projecting the property acquired by him in an illegal manner as an untainted property," reads the ED's remand note.

On January 29, the ED had raided a private residence used by Hemant in New Delhi that was rented by the Jharkhand government and seized Rs 36,34,500 cash stashed in a cupboard. Hemant rejects the allegation, saying he was never in possession of any illegal cash. In its production petition in a Ranchi court, the ED stated they also recovered "other documents linked to the investigation being conducted into the matter of acquisition of landed properties by fraudulent means".

Prior to his arrest, Hemant got the alliance—JMM, Congress, Rashtriya Janata Dal and Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist)—MLAs nominate his father Shibu Soren's trusted lieutenant Champai Soren as its leader and JMM's leader of the legislative party. Champai, 67, took oath as chief minister on February 2. However, Champai's floor test win over the BJP-led Opposition doesn't assure long-term stability to the JMM-led regime, for the state is scheduled to hold assembly polls in October, besides the parliamentary election.

Indeed, the coming months are crucial for Hemant. With his father Shibu Soren semi-retired from politics and his wife Kalpana Soren not yet graduating from a homemaker to being his successor, as he desired, the JMM will sorely miss his services as a campaigner if he fails to obtain a judicial reprieve or bail. Hemant's sister-in-law and JMM legislator Sita Soren (wife of his late brother Durga Soren), is opposed to Kalpana being given any leadership role in the party or the government. Thus, the 48-year-old leader's absence may trigger a battle of one-upmanship in the party, which, with its 29 MLAs, is the single-largest in the assembly.

But the arrest, coming as it does on the eve of the Lok Sabha polls, can also potentially provoke the numerically significant tribal community in the state and trigger a sympathy vote for the JMM. Jharkhand, a state with 28 per cent tribal population, has 28 of its 81 assembly seats and five of its 14 Lok Sabha constituencies reserved for Scheduled Tribes (STs). Hemant is from the dominant Santhal tribe. His party, therefore, is well placed to try and link his arrest with a narrative of alleged anti-tribal action by the BJP government at the Centre. If it catches the popular imagination, it can emerge as a major challenge for the BJP-led NDA, which has 12 Lok Sabha MPs from Jharkhand—11 from BJP and one from alliance partner All Jharkhand Students' Union. The state BJP, led by Babulal Marandi, another Santhal tribal leader, is trying hard to project Hemant's arrest as the logical conclusion of a corruption case. However, the BJP will have to walk the extra mile to prevent a possible tribal backlash.

Champai's winning the confidence motion was not just the completion of a mandatory legislative practice, it was also a confidence-booster to the ruling alliance as to the intactness of its absolute majority in the assembly.

Jharkhand, which has seen 12 governments and three spells of President's rule since its formation in November 2000, has largely seemed like a textbook case of political uncertainty. Of the 12 CMs, only the BJP's Raghubar Das completed five years in office. The confidence motion victory may have put only a temporary cap on political uncertainty. ■

TAKEAWAYS

- **The new Champai Soren government won the trust vote in the Jharkhand assembly, polling 47 votes**
- **It was necessitated when ED arrested JMM chief Hemant Soren on January 31 for alleged money-laundering**
- **Soren accuses BJP of being 'anti-tribal', hopes to influence tribal vote in LS, assembly polls**
- **But Soren faces a legal challenge; JMM may lose its star campaigner if he doesn't get relief**

THE BJP IS RELYING ON A NARRATIVE OF CORRUPTION AGAINST JMM TO STOP A POTENTIAL TRIBAL BACKLASH